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Sufism as World Literature

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Sufi Islam and Its Teachings

As an international student from Karakalpakstan, an autonomous country within Uzbekistan, Central Asia, I have developed a deep connection with the creative writing and poetry, especially of many from Islamic world. Jalaliddin Rumi, Hafiz or Darwish – they have a sharp pen for expressing love, inner turmoil, or a desire for something better than one's own. Many of these writers I have mentioned had a special connection with God, and practiced Sufi Islam. It is not just loving the religion of one's own, but sinking into it and seeking purification through fully devoting oneself to it.

Jean During talks about how music can have therapeutic dimensions in the context of Islam, and how followers of the religion see music as a way of healing and preventing illnesses. In this sense, people experience physiological, psychological, and emotional effects while participating in rituals accompanied by music. Sufi *zikr* is a practice of repeating heavenly names while engaging in rhythmic singing and dance. This practice is known for impacting on participants' state of awareness significantly. Similar to the examples stated above, Sufis also try to create a trance-like condition by using *ney* (flute) and percussion instruments such as the *daf*, producing a meditative rhythmic pulse. As Jean During points out, these musical stimuli produce totally involuntary body reactions influencing pulse rate and breathing patterns.

Sufis interpret their experiences with the help of a theological framework. The practitioner feels close to God by purifying themselves, and by allowing their body and mind to enter an altered state of consciousness. The emotional intensity experienced during *zikr* is seen as a manifestation of divine presence or spiritual awakening. All of the rituals are live and impersonal between the musician and the patient, and among the worshippers. A shared belief is that if they perform or sing in a particular way, a divine could help heal the illness or make connection with God.

It was interesting to read and being reintroduced to Sufism from an English translation perspective. I learned that Sufis purified themselves by turning to God and seeking forgiveness (*tawbah*), by having a faith that God is the most generous for those who have good intentions (*ikhlas*), and by remembering heavenly Quran verses and names in both good and bad situations (*dhikr* or *zikr*). I have spent roughly six hours on the readings. It includes making annotations, taking some notes, and taking ten minutes of breaks. I usually spend similar amounts of time on my other heavy-reading class, Intro to International Development. The video about what Sufism is and the reading about remembrance (*dkhir*) were easy to understand, because I already had some background knowledge about the topics, and they were simply easy to digest, one chunk at a time without advanced English vocabulary. *Tawbah* and *Ikhlas* were harder to read, primarily because of many religious figures being mentioned frequently. The readings were fillers to my knowledge of what Sufism was in the past and how it has evolved throughout history over various geographical places, how Muslims recite God and on which occasions, and why Sufism in particular is a combination of music and religion. Some questions left me pondering after the readings, such as does Sufism separate itself as one branch of Islam, or are they inseparable?

How do current Muslims devote themselves, for example, in Turkey as Dervish practices have been banned?